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At a time when the UPSC journey is being reshaped by AI and content creators, aspirants and coaches weigh in on the pros and cons

THE GREAT COACHING DISRUPTION



Saumya Dubey

After a long wait, the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) 2026 prelims results were released last week. Neha (name changed), 23, a humanities student, did not clear it. She is upset, she says, but was not banking on clearing the civil services examination in her first attempt.

UPSC is one of India's most prestigious competitive examinations for recruiting senior government administrators, and has long been tied to prestige, social mobility and job security. The success rate is below 1% – which is why entire neighbourhoods, such as Old Rajinder Nagar and Mukherjee Nagar in Delhi, came up around its preparation.

Today, increasingly, aspirants like Neha are preparing for the UPSC (which has three stages: preliminary, main and interview) by themselves. The reasons are many, from circumventing expensive coaching fees to creating hyper-personalised study material. Neha didn't want to leave her Nagpur home to enrol in a coaching centre, so she paid over ₹1 lakh to enrol in a year-long online classroom by a well-known Delhi-based institute. It didn't add any incremental value though, and she often found it difficult to schedule a weekly one-on-one session with her mentor. So, she left the course midway and turned to self-study and a new coach: books, downloadable material, short-form explainer videos, and Artificial Intelligence (AI).

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The novel is set on a disputed planet where a captive woman is forced to battle an unknown enemy; (below) the International Booker-shortlisted author Bora Chung. (GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK)

DIFFICULT BY DESIGN

Bora Chung's *Red Sword* is audacious and often baffling. Is that a flaw, or the point?

Anil Menon

In Bora Chung's new novel *Red Sword*, Chrisna, a slave/ warrior of the colonising "Imperials", is forced to fight, for unclear reasons, a monstrous enemy referred to as the "white aliens". The novel is a rinse-repeat sequence of imperial oppression; sword-versus-laser fights; escape-and-capture from either aliens or Imperials; clones dealing with Xeroxed memories; and a few matter-of-fact sex scenes.

The book's blurb makes no mention of any of the above features, but it does helpfully note that the story "draws upon" the Korean history of the Qing Empire forcing Koreans to battle Russia. I would have inferred no such allegorical connection from the novel itself. This is probably indicative of my limitations, not the novel's. What I know of Korea mostly comprises stuff I've watched on TV (dreamy androgynous romances, zombie outbreaks in medieval Korean kingdoms, a colonial legacy, and exactly one K-Pop song – Psy's 'Gangnam Style').

The novel's repetitive, monotonous narration makes it a hard read. It was Vonnegut who said, I think, that reading some novels can feel like being married to a perpetually ill spouse. I didn't enter into that sort of intimacy with Chung's novel, translated from the Korean by Anton Hur. But I hovered on the threshold, admiring the patient's intractability, and stoically awaiting the arrival of the last chapter.

Trauma of war

There are two kinds of unreadability when it comes to novels. The first variety is the product of an author's incompetence and the other stems from their originality. Now,



Red Sword
Bora Chung, trs Anton Hur
Pan Macmillan
₹399

any single novel can't prove an author is incompetent. But a body of work is more revealing. Originality is a persistent ailment; incompetence is not. Authors generally improve with practice; the truly original have no such hero's journey.

In Chung's case, I believe it is her originality, not incompetence, which characterises her peculiar stories. She's got a style that doesn't care about characterisation, plot realism, place specificity or emotional warmth of any kind. Her paper people go through traumatic events, they suffer, they have sex, they die; sometimes in non-causal order. She tells us they feel this emotion or that, but it all feels unreal. Her characters are presented as human, but there is a singular lack of depth to their actions and experiences which leaves one uncertain they are human.

For example, we are told a man is badly wounded in battle – "from his hip to his armpit, there was a black line where a ray had grazed him" – and that he "grimaced and gritted his teeth".

Then having dispensed with this behavioural routine, he proceeds with the adventure. At another point, Chrisna and her fellow prisoners are taken back to their cells after a particularly brutal battle. The author tells us: "The prisoners were given a rare, delicious feast that night. But very few of them ate without guilt or dread. Most of them were thinking of their fallen friends. As well as the Imperials who had forbidden them from using guns and shot them instead."

The flatness of the descriptions, their summarised quality and the lack of variety in the class of people being described isn't an isolated case though. If the aim is to represent the trauma of fighting the wars of one's colonial rulers, then this style is certainly one way to go about it. Especially since these people are copies of copies of copies of people who possibly did feel and act like actual humans might. Chung rather grudgingly gives them labels, but even these are often just colour labels: "white alien", "Light Green Skirt", "Indigo Skirt".

Writing paper people

The many tiresome fight sequences remind me of Japanese Isekai gamebooks. These books, as numerous as beetles, often have characters with anime-style features, fixed personality traits and stylised gestures engaging in pages and pages of combat. In comparison, Chung's action sequences are models of Beckettian restraint. In any case, I

don't think the style is specific to this work. It seems to be how Chung prefers to write her characters. Her earlier work, the International Booker Prize-shortlisted *Cursed Bunny* which brought her to international attention, is also filled with people strolling around the uncanny valley. There, in the story 'Goodbye, My Love', she has her narrator remark: "I wonder whether the concept of the 'uncanny valley' can be applied to behaviour as much as it does to appearance." It is an original and interesting question and perhaps *Red Sword* seeks to answer this question in the affirmative.

I have insinuated this is an unreadable novel. That needn't be a strike against the book. Many works we now consider great are unreadable – think Joyce's *Finnegans' Wake*. What matters is that this is also an interesting book – for its style and obduracy. Over the years, Chung has garnered a following for her genre-blending fiction with readers often commending her imaginative storytelling and exploration of themes such as patriarchy, capitalism and social inequality. This book is for such readers, and as such, needs no other defence.

The reviewer is an author, most recently of The Coincidence Plot.



The body corps

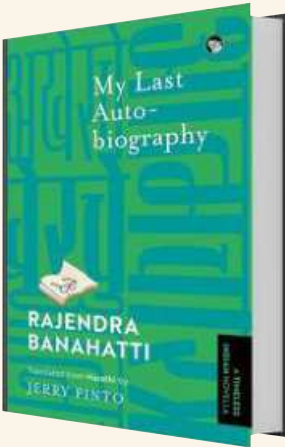
Two recent Marathi novellas in translation examine the question of the purpose of life

Meenakshi Shivram

There is the pain of being widowed after having remained married for 75 years in Marathi novelist Rajendra Banahatti's *My Last Autobiography*. There is the irritability of the children who are unable to understand the whims of the old man. There are friends who are so old as well that they cannot drop by to meet each other. There is the slowing down of the body that once used to go on treks, now unable to climb stairs. There is the dependence on caretakers. And yet, this novella is far from a sad story. Filled with humour and descriptive fineness, Banahatti delivers a literary coup.

My Last Autobiography comes alive through translator Jerry Pinto's admirable capture of the irreverent tenor and repetitive rhythm of a nonagenarian. At 94, the protagonist is writing his third autobiography, musing on whether death has somehow forgotten him.

The narrator is an engineer, whose name he thinks is perhaps still etched on the side of a bridge in Satara. He loves perfumes and pungent food. He fears dogs, darkness, climbing trees and swimming. His analysis of his children's traits is filled with love for the quirks of human nature. He says of his youngest son Bandu, who he unregretfully forced to become a doctor, that he is morose, secretive and introverted: "Some people are like that. They are perennially lost, irritated, angry. However successful they may be, they are always dissatisfied." And there is the anguished self-reflection that sees through the fragility of his assumptions: "Was my nagging making him irritable? Had he become like this because I had lived so long?"



My Last Autobiography
Rajendra Banahatti, trs Jerry Pinto
Speaking Tiger
₹399

Banahatti's narrative style is astonishing: while everything is from the viewpoint of the first-person, the reader catches the unsaid counter-point. Even while the old man insists that his son does not understand him, you do get to see the care and concern of that son. Even as the old man insists that just because one appears to be closer to death, one need not be philosophical or spiritual, one gets to see both these aspects in his attitude to life. The obliquely shared glimpses into guilt, fear and sorrow are all wrapped in love, humour and the ludicrousness of the purposelessness of an ordinary life.

Chasing a dream

Kamal Desai's 1975 novella *The Woman Who Wore a Hat* is usually read as a feminist piece – written as it is by a woman, about societal perceptions around the role of women. However, if this work, translated here by Shanta Gokhale, can be allowed to escape its limited feminist trappings, its philosophical

examination of the purpose of life can be profitably foregrounded.

Five old men meet every evening in a house that has an octagonal-shaped drawing room. Each of them carries a tale of loss, separation, grief and low self-esteem. Each individual life has scars – a lost child, a broken marriage, insecurity, dependence. All leading to the big picture of helplessness. The octagonal drawing room is like a giant octopus arm that can devour; where even flowers are destined to wilt.

Excitement enters their lives in the form of a nameless young woman who wears a hat. Men and women alike are triggered by the presence of this mysterious person who has no memory of her past. Her absence or loss of identity does not bother her as it does those around her. She is driven only by the passion to make a film – to replicate, if possible, a Disneyland in Maharashtra. And for the sake of this passion, she is willing to let her female body be used by people who can see nothing more than the body.

Just as in Virginia Woolf's *A Room of One's Own*, where the author imagines Shakespeare's equally gifted sister running away from home in search of a theatre where her talent can be



The Woman Who Wore a Hat
Kamal Desai; trs Shanta Gokhale
Speaking Tiger
₹399

showcased, we have here a woman who chases a single dream. While the world is preoccupied with knowing who she belongs to, she is wholly absorbed in her creative pursuits.

The Marathi cadence

Desai was ahead of her times. In 1975, years before postmodernism had become popular, she employed a back-and-forth dismembered narration. The story has loose ends which she does not bother to tie up neatly. There are bits and pieces of individual stories that can be patched together. But the author leaves the mysteries intact. Did the woman really lose her memory? Does she have a death wish? How did she die? Looking for definitive answers to some of these questions points to a mindset that expects reality to have causal links that can render matters explanatory. To answer the puzzle is to determine its meaning in the only way in which we know to assess reality. The woman who wore a hat refuses to be bound by such claims to realism or reality.

Pinto and Gokhale recreate the Marathi cadence of these two novellas with adroitness. Theirs is a translation through which the original inflections peep out. While Pinto retains the endearing way of referring to one's partner only as a pronoun or "Aaho", Gokhale describes a wall clock that rings in the hour with: "Two tiny sparrows peck-peck-pecked at grain on either side of the gently swinging pendulum." It's windfall time for Marathi literature in translation.

The reviewer is a Sahitya Akademi translation award winner, and the editor of 250 Years Of Jane Austen: Indian Responses.

BROWSER

Cape Elsewhere
Siddharth Dasgupta

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In this collection of 52 poems journeying through cities like Pune, Lucknow, Paris and Amsterdam, the poet blends memory, migration, longing and belonging. Dasgupta celebrates human fragility, beauty and the emotional landscapes of home, movement and elsewhere lives.



Yellow is the Colour of Falsehood
Jaya G. Nair

Paridhi Publications
₹150
This debut poetry collection by the ISRO engineer-turned-writer is a meditation on everyday life. The 35 poems in this volume reflect on the whole gamut of emotions as well as varied experiences, connections and possibilities.



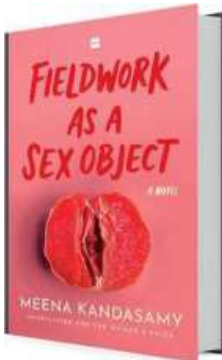
Villa Coco
Andrew Sean Greer

Sceptre
₹699
In this coming-of-age novel set in Italy and written in the author's trademark witty style, "expect princesses, pugs, weasels, and a few surprises along the way" says Greer on Instagram. The author was awarded the 2018 Pulitzer Prize for his novel Less.



Fieldwork as a Sex Object
Meena Kandasamy

HarperCollins
₹599
The Women's Prize-shortlisted author returns with a novel that is a scathing takedown of the Indian manosphere. The story unravels around a London-based privileged student activist who goes viral following a deepfake sex video.



Romila Thapar on secularism and democracy, and why the appeal of Hindutva must be understood through history

‘NEHRUVIAN ELITE NOT RESPONSIBLE FOR RISE OF HINDUTVA’

G. Sampath
sampath.g@thehindu.co.in

Romila Thapar, an extraordinary scholar known for shaping our understanding of ancient Indian history and for instituting critical inquiry at the heart of Indian historiography, has come out with her memoir, *Just Being* (Seagull Books). It is an expansive tapestry spanning several decades and continents, melding the personal and the ‘world-historical’. In a freewheeling chat about her book in New Delhi, Professor Thapar spoke about the past and the present. Edited excerpts:

Question: Would you have approached the writing of your memoir differently if you were not someone trained to write about the past?

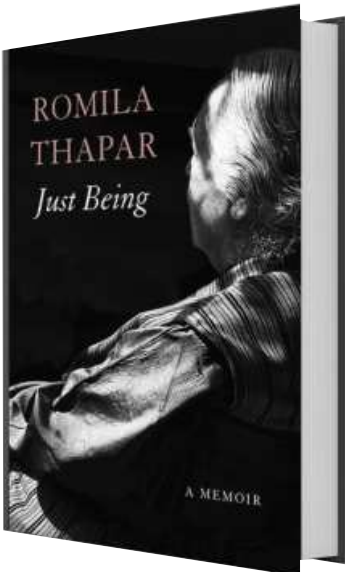
Answer: Yes, there is a difference. Most memoirs, written by various people, are narratives about the past and the emphasis is on the narrative and the time and place in which it was written. Where the author is a historian it does bring in a certain difference. The historian is interested in more than the narrative, because the interest extends to seeing the event in the wider context of the particular time in which it happened. A historical understanding of a time or an event does involve something of an analysis – however brief it may be – and therefore either touches upon or explores more fully the meaning of an event, and not leave it just as a description of what happened. The time, the place, and the persons involved cannot be set aside. Explaining all of that involves far more than just a mention of what happened. And of course, every reader wants to know more.

Q: Some political analysts fault the liberal, Nehruvian elite for the rise of Hindutva. They accuse them of having never engaged with the ‘subaltern Hindu’ the way Hindutva did and does. Would you agree?

A: At the time of Indian independence, I was 15 and we were conscious of nationalism and the coming of a free India. But we were not too aware of Hindutva lurking in the background, or making a bid for authority. Nationalism, it was thought, could only be an essentially secular ideology and its association with anything religious was marginal, if at all. Hindu and Muslim nationalisms did not have primacy

as nationalisms. They were better viewed rather as aspects of the marginal role of religion in support of politics. There were some people who thought it to be a good thing that nationalism had the approval of religion.

I certainly would not hold the liberal Nehruvian elite responsible for the rise of Hindutva. There was a clear separation between the two, with secularism more widely supported to begin with, and also being seen as essential to nationalism. Gradually this changed. The explanation for the rise of Hindutva has to be sought in other changes as well. I would also attribute it to those agencies that supported Partition. These included organisations that endorsed the ideology of Hindutva. They were accumulating authority and asserting it through some of the new agencies of the state that were being established, and the latter did on occasion take positions that were not in conformity with democratic norms. The question that needs to be asked is why Hindutva forces were given this authority both within these organisations and more generally in society as a whole. Hindutva was encouraged by those who felt that contemporary decisions about



The Indian middle class had accepted the colonial theory, emphasised by James Mill, that India consisted of two communities – the larger Hindu and the somewhat smaller Muslim – and that the two were permanently hostile to each other



Romila Thapar, historian and scholar. (NAVEEN KISHORE)

The other colonial theory that was eagerly appropriated was the claim that the Hindus were descended from, and lived in, the land of the Aryans (*pitribhumi*), and that Hinduism drew from the land where Aryan teaching was propagated (*punyabhumi*). Where the Arya lived was associated with purity of race and where the Hindu religion originated was a sacred area.

The creation of the Indian identity has drawn from the supposed historical features on which it was built. The study of the Vedic texts led to the notion that the people who founded the community were a race of Aryans. Race as a social category has now been questioned. But a century ago, race and religion were fundamental to the creation of communities, and these two continue to hover.

The contradiction was that highly centralised theories were also sought to be incorporated into ideas of secularism and democracy, which assumed a society to be less centralised. This raised problems that we are battling to this day. Secularism obviously confronts that which makes for Hindutva and its basic religious givens. That explains why there are problems with explaining what the relationship is that Hindutva has not only to Hinduism but to religion in general.

Democracy also poses problems for Hindutva since it does not accept the religious hierarchy inherent in Hinduism and religion in general.

The rights of citizenship are primary and there can be no democracy if they are absent. A question that is central today is: How can the equivalent of citizenship in a democratic format be made functional in Indian society if the agencies that uphold democracy are made ineffective? Hence the fears of the possible collapse of various social agencies, such as the judiciary, education, and state institutions, that uphold a society.

Read the full interview online.



Scan the QR code to watch Romila Thapar in conversation on magazine.thehindu.com

Sudha G. Tilak

The books of Irwin Allan Sealy feel like long conversations held on railway platforms, in crumbling *dak* bungalows, and in the corridors of memory, where reminiscences, wit, and wisdom interrupt one another. He writes with the confidence of a storyteller who knows exactly when to tease, when to provoke, and when to disappear into smoke.

The author of *The Trotter-nama*, *The Everest Hotel*, and *From Yukon to Yucatan* returns this time in pursuit of yoginis, those ancient incarnations of feminine power, fierce guardians and avengers. These are women who inhabit sculpted temple walls, forgotten shrines, and museum showcases, carrying in their broken stone bodies their other-galactical residue of wiccan capabilities, awe, and terror.

If you have not encountered them in the ruins of Hirapur or in the lonely corners of the Government Museum in Chennai, you will meet them here in this book, dotted with elegant illustrations, summoned into



GETTY IMAGES

Sorceress in stone and flesh

A wandering, eccentric meditation on female power and the strange hunger for transcendence

motion by Sealy’s restless imagination. (Also, is it okay to want more books with illustrations?) In *Flying Yoginis*, Sealy drifts

between travel writing, philosophical rumination, and wry observation with little concern for literary categories. The book is at

once a travelogue, a spiritual musing, a journal, and a meditation on female force across time and geography. Encounters, digressions, and reflections gather loosely, like conversations overheard on overnight journeys.

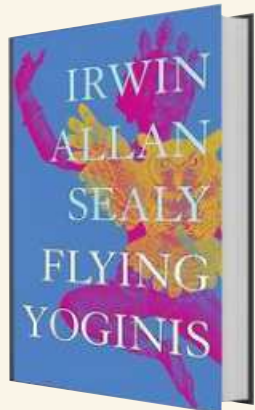
At the centre of the book is Yoginissima, the elusive yogini in Sealy’s mind whom he gives chase to across museums, archives, and memory. She first appears fleeing him on a duck, playful and unreachable in his mind.

Sealy admits that his fascination with yoginis emerged only after his disappointment with the masculine yogi tradition whose displays of endurance, conquest over pain, and militant bodily discipline left him cold. The yogini, by contrast, becomes for him a figure of compassion and moral reckoning: maternal yet dangerous, capable of restoring order to a broken world and schooling the wayward.

The journey carries him from Kanchipuram digs whose excavated yoginis were transported to museums across the globe in the last century. Off he goes in search of their *darshan*, from Kansas City and Minneapolis to Montgomery in the U.S. In Minneapolis, he encounters

a damaged yogini from Kanchipuram displayed in the middle of a museum park, missing limbs and a breast, yet still radiating authority. In Kansas, he finds another, round-faced and tattooed, part matriarch and part goddess in the museum.

Elsewhere, the yogini escapes stone altogether. She emerges in flesh and blood in his mind’s eye; in Rosa Parks, in Carson McCullers, and in unnamed women of the American South negotiating race, colour and exclusion with quiet ferocity. There is also Gulbadan Begum, Babur’s daughter celebrated in an American book, who survived shipwreck on a



Flying Yoginis
Irwin Allan Sealy
Seagull Books
₹699

pilgrimage to Mecca, and she becomes another kind of yogini: voyager, biographer, and witness.

Sealy’s book, which begins as a search for sculpted deities, gradually discovers living women shaped by courage and endurance. His world of the yogini soon expands beyond temples into bus stations, museums, anti-war manifestos and roadside conversations.

The final section, a four-part poem titled ‘Death of Siri’, turns inward. Here, back from his American wanderings, Sealy meditates on the indignities of urban life and the fragile determination required simply to keep walking through Dehradun’s crowded pavements and ATM-lined streets. And a canine yogini, lame with limpid eyes, keeps him grounded. There is melancholy here, but also stubborn grace.

Flying Yoginis is a genre-defying meditation on women while wandering and, in the end, is about both.

The reviewer is the author of *Temple Tales and translator of Hungry Humans*.

Student waiting to appear for the UPSC exam outside a centre in New Delhi. (SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA)

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

At mealtimes, she would watch 2-3 exam strategy videos of UPSC toppers; she subscribed to 10-15 Telegram channels, and downloaded PDFs into a folder named Mission CSE. She used Claude, feeding bulky government reports such as India's annual Economic Survey into it along with her own notes, and asked Anthropic's popular model to summarise it in a language she could understand – something no institute can replicate at scale. Of the 7-8 hours Neha studied daily, she dedicated an hour to Claude. “The syllabus is so vast that on most days you go to bed feeling you haven’t covered what you should have,” she says.

But she isn’t giving up. Next year, she plans to prepare the same way, with Gemini AI as her aid. Her cousin successfully used Google’s AI assistant to crack her CAT exams and get into IIM. Neha plans to prompt it to generate topic-wise questions sorted by difficulty.

Can AI crack UPSC?

Gemini AI is what Prateek Mudgal, 25, from Aligarh, who secured All India Rank (AIR) 54 in CSE 2025, used to score his answer-writing practice against past toppers’ responses, and generate key points on the art and architecture of various medieval history dynasties. In the actual exam, there was a question on the Chandela dynasty and he found this



exercise immensely helpful in answering that question. He also fed keyword prompts from his DAF (Detailed Application Form) to generate potential interview questions. For instance, he fed the term ‘Youth Parliament’ and Gemini gave possible questions around the importance of it. “The key is to use it within a limit,” he says.

Students share that they upload their education background, hometown, optional subjects, work experience and hobbies into AI, and prompts along these lines: “Act as the UPSC Board Member. Ask me one question at a time based on my DAF. Score my responses. Challenge weak answers.” Others ask Claude and ChatGPT to interrupt answers, challenge assumptions, play a sceptical panel member, and ask uncomfortable questions. It helps them develop composure, address rambling and lack of structure. There is infinite practice, instant

feedback and no embarrassment.

“Earlier, revision meant carrying stacks of notes,” says U. Harshaveena from Chennai, who secured AIR 257 in 2025. “Now, AI turns my handwritten pages into crisp flash cards and quizzes me whenever I have free time.” Patna-based Priya Kumari, AIR 232 (in 2025, her fifth attempt), adds that AI helped her the most at the interview stage.

From coaching halls to chatbots

A decade ago, authority resided with institutions; teachers were

gatekeepers. Now, Telegram admins shape opinion, YouTube educators have cult followings, and Reddit communities audit institutes in real time. “Free content is the first hook,” says a Delhi-based faculty at a coaching institute, on condition of anonymity, of Telegram, which has with its anonymity and closed groups become many aspirants’ primary community. “If one video gets a lakh views and 1,000 students pay, job well done,” he continues.

Over the last two years, AI has been supplanting, if not replacing, traditional modes of

coaching and preparing for competitive examinations. ChatGPT has Study Mode, Google has Gemini Live, and Anthropic has Claude Voice; the last one, aspirants say, is increasingly being used as a discussion partner rather than a quiz machine. Specialised tools such as SuperKalam, an AI-powered UPSC preparation platform, also offer personalised study plans, daily targets and progress tracking. This has sounded the death knell for several smaller institutes, including Delhi’s Chahal Academy, IAS Gurukul and 99 Notes, which downed

their shutters in recent months. Anmol Goyal, founder and CEO of 99 Notes, which had around 600 students until last year, said in news interviews: “Our institute shut down, and AI was a key factor. AI has become a significant part of UPSC preparation, and aspirants are moving towards it.”

The ‘artificial’ classroom

Not to be left behind, coaching centres are using AI such as Claude, NotebookLM and ChatGPT, says the anonymous faculty member. “How they are prompting is what differentiates them. That nuance comes from experience in this ecosystem,” says the above mentioned Delhi-based coaching faculty member. The broader trend, educators explain, has been a push towards brevity and sharper content delivery, particularly for prelims preparation, where concise revision-friendly material is increasingly valued.

“Content is no longer scarce; attention and direction are.



In the age of social media, you can’t ignore Reels and YouTube Shorts. Consume it mindfully instead of doomscrolling. Short-form content can never replace regular classes

ZEYAU MUSTAFA
Teacher & founder, Dr. UPSC channel on YouTube



I enrolled in several courses but most of them were a waste of money. The market is fragmented. AI helped me the most at the interview stage

PRIYA KUMARI
AIR 232 in CSE 2025



With AI, it has become even easier to prepare without coaching. But niche optional papers still favour specialists, and mains exam answers still benefit from human feedback

ARHIJET YADAV
Founder, UPSCprep.com platform on YouTube



I asked Gemini AI to generate 4-5 key points on the art and architecture of medieval history dynasties. In the exam, there was a question on Chandela dynasty. The key is to use it within a limit

PRATEEK MUDGAL
AIR 54 in CSE 2025

This is why we built alchemist study, an agentic AI architecture that personalises study paths, evaluates answers, and frees our faculty to do what algorithms cannot – mentor,” says M. Senthil Kumar, director of Aram IAS Academy, Chennai. “The future of coaching is not human versus machine, but machines handling scale while teachers handle judgment, doubt and the resolve to persist.”

At Officers IAS Academy, Chennai, director Israel Jebasingh says, “We put our current affairs videos daily and use AI in prelims, mains and all preparation material, as additional support.” Last year’s AIR 2 Rajeshwari Suve M., who had cleared Tamil Nadu’s TNPSCT exam the previous year and enrolled as a deputy collector, “was a student of our classroom,” he adds. “We have an exclusive R&D team, with almost 25 members. In our academy, there has been no drop in student numbers [around 1,200 annual

Affordable classes

Legacy institutes have largely maintained or increased their fees over time. Vajiram & Ravi’s flagship GS Foundation programme has gone up from roughly ₹1.45 lakh in 2021 to nearly ₹2 lakh today. The first real disruption came around four years ago with the emergence of the low-cost tier – digital-first players such as PWOnlyIAS and Khan Sir who offered comparable courses for under ₹12,000. Now, with AI and a new wave of online platforms bringing down prices even further, “legacy institutes are under threat,” says a senior person at a large coaching platform. He calls the AI and digital-only dynamic (recorded lectures, modular courses and subscription-based learning) as the “Jio model”. But the democratisation of access has also created new challenges. Lower costs online mean more people can stay in the preparation cycle for longer periods, and thereby remain unemployed.

THE FEE GAP: WHAT PREPARATION COSTS

GENERAL STUDIES FOUNDATION PROGRAMME

Vajiram and Ravi	₹1,80,000 – ₹1,95,000
Officers IAS Academy	₹1,89,000
Forum IAS	₹1,29,800
PW Only IAS	₹11,800
Khan Sir, Patna	From ₹8,000

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



JOURNEY TO THE END OF THE WORLD

From Everest to Antarctica, fragile landscapes are feeling the pressure of tourism. Here’s how to explore the White Continent more responsibly



number of people that can be on any landing site at a time, biosecurity measures to prevent the spread of invasive species and diseases, and guidelines for wildlife watching.

Rao thinks back to her excursion to Deception Island, an erstwhile whaling station at the fringe of the Antarctic Peninsula. There, rusting remnants of the terrible mass hunting and slaughter of humpback and fin whales for meat and oil (until as recently as 1994) are scattered in the midst of breathtaking natural beauty and countless penguins and seals. “It was a stark reminder that even the most remote corners of our planet have felt the impact of human activity,” she says. “But it also gave me hope. Over the years, so much effort and global cooperation has gone into protecting Antarctica through scientific research, conservation policies and strict international agreements.”

But why is it important to protect Antarctica? Juan Cristóbal Del Pedregal Bravo, Senior Commercial Director at Antarctica21, a Chile-based boutique cruise company known for their sustainable practices, has an explanation. “Antarctica is one of the last truly untouched wildernesses on earth, and it is also one of the most scientifically important,” he says. This is apart from the fact that the Antarctic ice sheet is the largest fresh body of water on earth, containing 90% of all ice on the planet. If that melts, sea levels would rise

Three questions to ask

How many passengers should a ship have?

Choose smaller, boutique ships for a more immersive experience. The writer travelled on the Magellan Explorer, which can carry a maximum of 76 passengers. It allowed for better interactions with the staff and more time during land excursions.

What kind of excursions must a tour offer?

Look for operators who offer a minimum of two shore landings or sea excursions to ensure a good mix of landscapes, wildlife and adventure.

What responsible tourism measures must the operator follow?

Engage only with companies that have regular presentations and talks by the crew (which helps create awareness about the beauty and fragility of the ecosystem), ensure strict adherence to regulatory measures, and offer passengers a choice to participate in citizen science/research programmes onboard (these help get consistent and widespread data inputs for scientists).

8,000 people visited

Antarctica each year, while in the 2023-24 season, the continent received 1,25,000 tourists. Seen in isolation, this doesn’t seem like a large number, but given how fragile this landscape is, it is frightening. And predictions show that if left unchecked, tourist numbers could reach half a million by 2033.

The reasons for this rapid increase are multifold, starting from the collective post-COVID appetite for travel, and the need to tick off imaginary “bucket lists” curated by social media influencers. There is also the darker notion of “last chance tourism”, which perhaps arises from a nagging realisation among the same segment of well-heeled, well-travelled folks that in the not-so-distant future, there may not be an Antarctica left to visit.

For Bhavna Rao, founder of the upscale travel company Encompass Experiences, her trip (though she has been arranging trips to Antarctica for clients since 2020, Rao herself got a chance to visit only in

December 2024) was spurred by the desire to see what several travellers had described to her as “transformational”. And it was. She recalls her first iceberg sighting as “opening the window and seeing it in the distance – massive, silent, almost surreal. In that moment, you realise how small we are in the [grand] scale of nature”.

Impact of human activity

Regulating tourism is tricky business in Antarctica, given that the continent does not belong to any sovereign nation, but is a space governed by the 1959 Antarctic Treaty that declares it a neutral, demilitarised zone meant for (peaceful) scientific research. It was only in 1991, when the International Association of Antarctica Tour Operators was set up, that the tourism industry had functional guidelines.

Most major cruise lines and travel operators to Antarctica are now part of this voluntary consortium, which has strict rules about the size of cruise ships, the

by almost 230 feet, with disastrous consequences across the world.

It’s not a luxury cruise

That is not to suggest that travel to Antarctica be avoided. Not at all. For one, Antarctica is isolated and spectacular, with no “destination dupes”. As Bravo says, “This combination of untouched nature, remarkable wildlife and profound remoteness creates an experience that is both rare and deeply meaningful for travellers.” More importantly, he also believes small-scale tourism can be a force for good. “Allowing travellers to witness the continent’s beauty and fragility first-hand helps foster a deeper appreciation for Antarctica and strengthens global support for its protection,” he adds.

So, the question is not whether tourism should exist – that ship has sailed, quite literally – but what kind of tourism should. The solution is to travel with companies that are committed to the principles of conservation and sustainability, while also supporting scientific research in the region. There are a handful of these, plying smaller ships with fewer passengers and multiple experts onboard.

When clients approach Rao for help with this trip, she begins with a discussion on why they want to go to Antarctica. “It’s important that travellers understand this is not a typical holiday. It’s an expedition,” she explains. “People often imagine it as a luxury cruise, but in reality, it is much more about discovery and learning about the environment. So, education is a big part of the planning process.”

Done right, casual visitors will return as staunch ambassadors for the continent, with a deeper understanding of why protecting Antarctica is vital for the future of our planet.

The independent journalist writes on travel, art and culture, sustainability and conservation.



Studying from home

For many aspirants, regional hubs, affordable internet, online classes, digital study material and AI have reduced the need to migrate to erstwhile hubs of UPSC coaching. “Location does not matter,” says Yadav of UPSCprep.com. “What matters is the willingness to learn, a good internet connection, and access to the right guidance.” He points to one of his earliest students, Viku L. Achumi, who cleared the exam and joined the Indian Police Service (IPS) in 2021, without ever leaving Nagaland. “Online platforms have opened new opportunities for women and rural aspirants,” adds Anshu Sharma, founder-director, Achievers IAS Academy in Bengaluru.

enrolments] due to AI or social media.”

Old school in new capsule

Meanwhile, legacy institutes such as Vajiram & Ravi, Rau’s IAS and Drishti IAS still emphasise structured material, faculty, peer group and a trusted voice to cut through the noise. Newer specialist platforms offer targeted support even for less popular optional subjects, such as Sanket Jain’s Psyche Simplified, for the psychology optional paper. This didn’t have many players earlier.

“With AI, it may have become easier to prepare without coaching,” says Abhijeet Yadav, who runs UPSCprep.com, a YouTube platform with 550,000 subscribers, but “niche optional papers still favour specialist teachers [as domain expertise is necessary]”, and main exam answers benefit from human feedback.

Jain argues that short-form content is weakening deep reading and answer-writing skills. According to him, reading the newspaper is what builds analytical depth and not watching summarised videos. It’s a point that Prashant Tiwari,

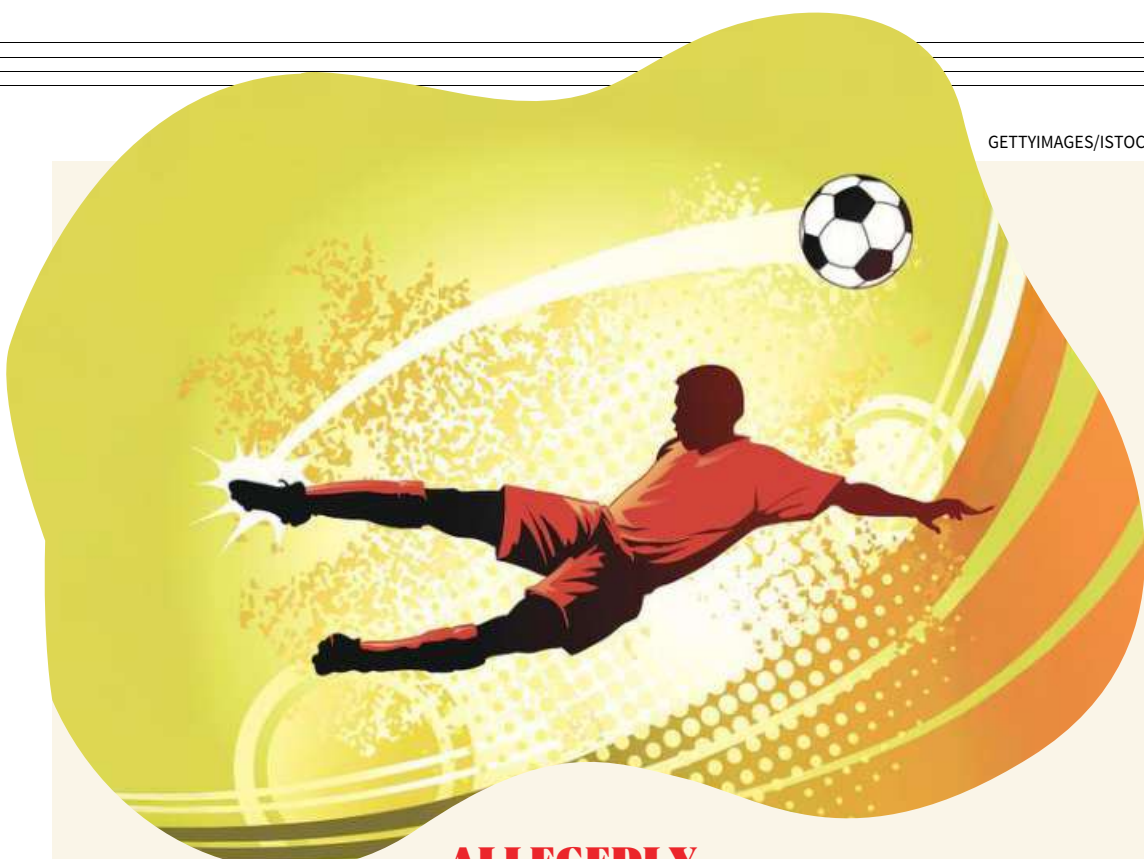
faculty member at Physics Wallah’s PW OnlyIAS – and the face of the current affairs explainer videos on YouTube channel UPSC Wallah – can get behind. He publishes daily current affairs videos that break down the day’s news from newspapers, for both Prelims and Mains preparation, and draws views in thousands.

“AI is a tool to help us; it is not an end-all method. Also, whatever data AI gives can be faulty or biased, so we should use our analytical ability to understand if it is useful or not,” says Chennai-based Arvind Radhakrishnan (son of IAS officer J. Radhakrishnan), who cleared the UPSC exam twice, once in 2022 when he ranked 361 and then in 2024 with rank 80.

“In 2022, ChatGPT was just a newspaper phenomenon; in 2024, I had the opportunity to use it myself. I did not depend on the AI engine completely for an answer. I just used it as a source to search for the data,” he says.

Technology may be reshaping preparation, but at the end of the day, traditional “mentoring and hand holding” remain essential, says Shubhangi Singh, a faculty member at Vajiram & Ravi. Because the highly competitive exam has not changed in its brutality. And the appeal goes beyond mere employment. “This job brings respect,” says Tiwari of PWOnlyIAS. “It raises the status of your family. With AI-driven firing happening everywhere, a government job brings certainty.”

The writer lives in Noida, works at a venture capital fund, and writes on pop culture, media and psychology.



GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK

ALLEGEDLY

Why is India not in the World Cup?

Our inevitable absence at the football tournament defies our greatness

own father this question. But Appa had obviously given it much thought. He had his own theory and never missed an opportunity to air it. He believed India would have easily qualified for the World Cup and also won it more times than even Brazil, provided the rules were slightly modified.

A football team, he said, should have the option to deploy 11 ‘by-runners’, just like how a cricket team can do for an injured batsman. The runners need not be of the same nationality as the football team. So the Indian football team should have the option of hiring, say, 11 Argentinian by-runners – but only for its forwards, defenders, mid-fielders, and goalkeeper. “Once the running and kicking part is outsourced, Indians will be unbeatable in football,” Appa liked to say. “That’s why we are so good at cricket. Not

much running, and after each run, you get a few minutes’ rest.”

But I told Katta the truth. “We are not in the World Cup because we did not qualify.”

“Why didn’t we qualify?” “We weren’t good enough,” I said.

My mother, who till then had been quietly reading the *Bhagavad Gita*, piped up. “Dei, what is that new country which has qualified? Kurkure or something.”

“It’s Kooraa Khao,” Katta said. “It’s Que-ra-sao,” Wife said. “How do you know,” I was shocked. “You don’t even follow football. Or any sport for that matter.”

“I do follow geography,” she said. “Can any of you point out Curaçao on the world map?”

As Katta and I looked at each other, Amma said, “Wherever it is, do you know its population? 1,56,000!”



G. Sampath, the author of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

The 8th century collection of Sanskrit stories, *Suka Saptati*, or *Seventy Tales of the Parrot*, was built around a frame narrative that would eventually shape one of the most influential story collections in world literature, the Arabic *Alf Layla wa Layla* – known in English as *One Thousand and One Nights*.

In the original Indian tale, a merchant left home on business, and his wife planned to use his absence to meet her lover. A talking parrot, left behind as her companion, intervened. Each night, when the woman prepared to slip out, the parrot began a story that delayed her departure. The tale always ended in suspense or with a pointed warning, persuading her to stay home. This continued for 70 nights, until the husband returned. Storytelling thus prevented adultery not by force, but by narrative control.

The story travelled along the monsoon winds and influenced the writing of the now lost Persian collection *Hazar Afsana*, meaning ‘a thousand tales’. When this material entered the Arabic-speaking world between the 8th and 10th centuries, it was absorbed into the expanding Abbasid (third major Islamic caliphate) cultural sphere, especially Baghdad. A new frame story emerged, again built around unfaithful wives.

A king, traumatised by the betrayal of his queen, would marry a new bride each night and have her killed by morning. The vizier’s daughter, Scheherazade, saved herself through storytelling, suspending her death by narrating tales that deferred the sentence. This was not merely a literary device but a moral negotiation. Absolute authority was tempered not by rebellion but by wisdom, patience, and persuasion. Storytelling became a civilising force,



Pages from *Tutinama*, a Persian translation of *Suka Saptati*. (WIKI COMMONS)



FROM CULT TO CULTURE

THE PARROT THAT FLEW TO BAGHDAD

How a collection of Sanskrit stories influenced *One Thousand and One Nights* and reflected the everyday concerns of Islamic society

turning rage into reflection and violence into restraint.

Capturing the world of Islam
The structure of *One Thousand and One Nights* reflected Islamic urban society. It was modular and expandable, allowing stories to be inserted endlessly, much like the oral sermons and *adab* (literature related to etiquette) narratives circulating in markets and mosques. Storytellers performed these tales in bazaars, caravanserais, and courts, addressing a mixed audience of merchants, artisans, women, and travellers. This rooted the collection in everyday Muslim life rather than elite theology.

The tales depicted a society governed by Islamic law yet full of contradiction, where piety stood alongside indulgence, and legal order alongside trickery and desire. It functioned as cultural grammar – characters sinned, suffered, repented, and were restored, reflecting a rhythm aligned with the Islamic moral imagination.

The collection also captured the institutional world of Islam. The caliph, especially Harun al-Rashid, appeared as both ruler and moral centre, wandering Baghdad in disguise to test the justice of his city. Though fictionalised, he embodied the ideal of the *amir al-muminin* (leader of the faithful), whose authority combined political power with religious legitimacy. Baghdad became the narrative axis, mirroring the Islamic conception of a just centre from which order radiated outwards.

Yet the tales revealed deep tensions within that society. Urban life brought constant encounters between law and desire, and wine drinking, erotic adventures, and deception appeared frequently despite religious prohibitions. Storytellers negotiated

these tensions through moral arcs in which excess led to downfall, deceit to punishment. The collection depicted a plural society too, where Muslims, Christians, Jews and others shared narrative space, reflecting the reality of *dhimmi* (non-Muslim) communities under Islamic rule.

India is never forgotten
The Indian presence in the collection survived in subtle but important ways, especially in travel narratives such as *Sindbad the Sailor*, where India formed part of the wider Indian Ocean world of trade and marvels. Arabic works such as *Ajaib al-Hind* (*Marvels of India*) informed this imagination, presenting the country as a land of wonders, commerce, and strange knowledge.

The collection’s growth continued into the Mamluk period (13th to 16th centuries), when Cairo replaced Baghdad as a cultural hub. There was never a single authoritative version. Different retellings reflected different Islamic contexts, organised around recurring concerns such as the rise and fall of dynasties echoing *Quranic* warnings, Sufi journeys from ego to surrender, and the commercial networks linking India, Arabia, and Africa. The number 1,001 suggested infinity itself.

Yet beneath all these layers, the original kernel of the *Suka Saptati* remained intact, the watchful parrot still spinning tale after tale, gesturing towards something older than any of these traditions: the anxieties of the merchants about wives left behind.



Devdutt Pattanaik is the author of 50 books on mythology, art and culture.

GOREN BRIDGE

Greed is not good

Both vulnerable, South deals

Bob Jones

Some hands with 5-4-2-2 distribution are well suited to a two no trump opening. South chose two clubs with this major-suit-oriented hand so he could get both of his suits in. North’s two no trump response showed a balanced hand with 8-10 points. He thought he was too good to pass four

hearts so he cue bid his diamond control, leading to this excellent slam.

South won the opening diamond lead with dummy’s king and drew trumps in three rounds. Without giving it much thought, he began to run his spades, believing that he would make an overtrick if the spades split 3-3 and just make his contract if they split 4-2. He didn’t bother to think what might happen if the

spades split 5-1, or worse. When East discarded on the second spade, South could no longer make his slam. He had to lose a spade and a club. Provided the trumps split 3-2, the slam was cold regardless of the split in spades. South should have drawn trumps, ending in dummy, and then run the 10 of spades. He might still make seven if East has the jack of spades, and no bad spade split could defeat him. Too bad.

NORTH
♠ 10 9
♥ A Q 7 5
♦ K 7 6 5
♣ 9 6 5

WEST
♠ J 8 7 6 2
♥ 4 3
♦ Q J 10
♣ Q 10 4

EAST
♠ 3
♥ 8 6 2
♦ 9 8 4 2
♣ K J 8 7 3

SOUTH
♠ A K Q 5 4
♥ K J 10 9
♦ A 3
♣ A 2

The bidding:
SOUTH 2♣
3♠
4♥
6♥
WEST Pass
Pass
Pass
All pass
NORTH 2NT
3NT
5♦
EAST Pass
Pass
Pass

Opening lead: Queen of ♦

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

All about theme music



This theme song featured a 22-piece big band orchestra and was inspired by Beethoven’s *The Tempest*. (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley

1 Born on June 21, 1932, Lalo Schifrin was a jazz composer best known for his television scores. In 1966, he composed the theme for a TV show with a motif that is now easily recognisable. If the meter (dash dash, dot dot) is Morse code for the letters M and I, which show was this?

2 This theme used to play across India every Sunday at 9 a.m. on one channel. An entire generation knows the lyrics by heart, introducing them to the legendary Urdu poet Gulzar. With music by Vishal Bharadwaj, which show was this?

3 This song was written by the creators of a long-running show. When they approached

Warner Bros., the only band that was available to record it was The Rembrandts. Initially reluctant to record it, they eventually did and at the last minute added some handclaps. Which show was it the theme for?

4 This iconic track was composed by Keith and Matthew Strachan and, since 1998, has been used in over 100 international versions of this TV game show. The main soundtrack is characterised by a dramatic, heartbeat-like rhythmic pulse and tense orchestral strings, designed to build suspense, just like the 12/15 questions. What show was this?

5 The theme of this TV show was composed by Danny Elfman in 1989 on the way home from a meeting. The demo was

recorded later that day. Since then, it has opened more than 800 episodes over 37 seasons. Which TV show theme was this, which ends in an iconic saxophone solo?

6 This TV show was a big hit on Indian TV in 1986. It was based on a book by an Indian writer, and featured sketches by his brother as well. The theme music was composed by Carnatic violinist L. Vaidyanathan but was played on a bamboo flute. Which iconic show was this?

7 The super-catchy theme song to this animated show was composed by Mark Mueller in 45 minutes. Its driving tempo, clever lyrics and ‘woo hoo’ have inspired thousands of covers on YouTube. Which Disney show was it – about a family helping

their patriarch safeguard his money?

8 The theme song of this animation lyrically explained the concept of the whole show. The video started with a polluted traffic jam as it zoomed in on the Earth. Which inspiring cartoon show ended with the iconic line ‘The power is yours’?

9 This theme song has been on the airwaves for more than six decades. Composed by Curt, Barbera and Hanna, it featured a 22-piece big band orchestra and was inspired by Beethoven’s *The Tempest*. Which song introduced you to a family in Bedrock?

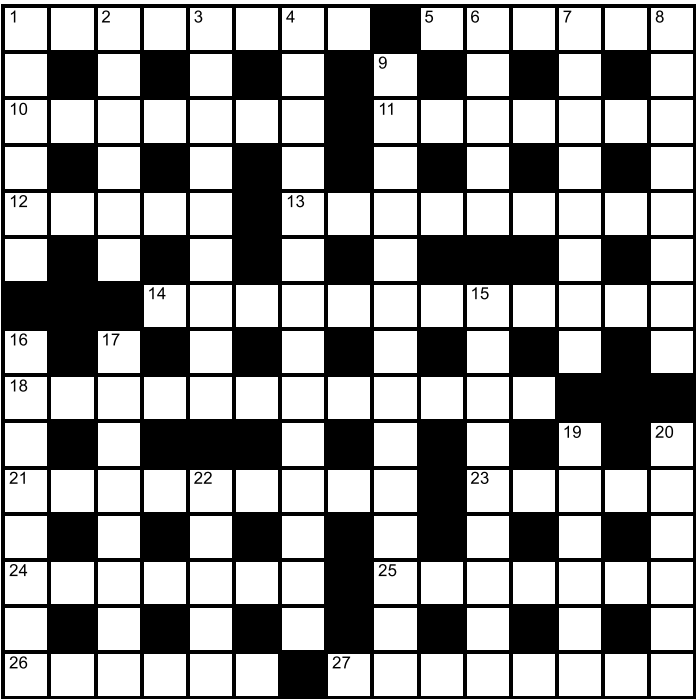
10 This instrumental track by Mark Snow was titled ‘Materia Primoris’. The iconic theme comprised his wife’s whistling, and the creepy echo effect was an accident. Which TV show’s theme was this that fittingly pre-empted a creepy episode?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’.
@bertyashley

- 1. Mission: Impossible
- 2. The Jungle Book
- 3. F.R.I.E.N.D.S
- 4. Who Wants To Be A Millionaire?
- 5. The Simpsons
- 6. Madjadh Days
- 7. DuckTales
- 8. Captain Planet
- 9. The Flintstones
- 10. The X-Files

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 61 (Set by Arden)

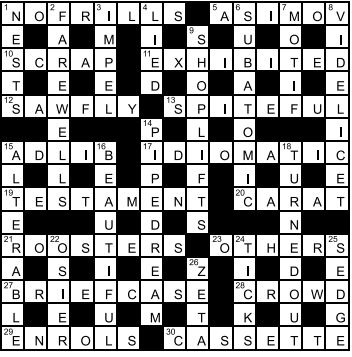


- Across**
- 1** Perhaps able to get one married shortly — it’s naturally fertilising (8)
 - 5** Rollover I have overlooked... (6)
 - 10** ...and committed to restrict (7)
 - 11** Old sailors found, say, a mini wearing girl (7)
 - 12** Found before court (5)
 - 13** Strange predilections — not done at face value (4,5)
 - 14** Propagation in half the country (12)
 - 18** Provide cleanest side for a diner (12)
 - 21** One on the wagon with a black paint (9)
 - 23** Cover empty drawer and copy (5)
 - 24** In my opinion, covering history is like a painting technique (7)
 - 25** Country in Europe, is not a representation (7)
 - 26** Some are present at a mid-week rush (6)
 - 27** Harry Morgan’s taking time for such a short distance (8)

- Down**
- 1** Breed born with wealth (6)
 - 2** Spruce up when finally consumed (6)
 - 3** “Pick-me-up after one” — sung in a flat pitch (9)
 - 4** Wind and clothesline — metaphorically, seen as a vulnerability (8,6)
 - 6** Story teller makes one sit up (5)

- 7** Perhaps Putin’s angry rival is getting clueless (8)
- 8** Detects record reprints — not counting the odd ones (8)
- 9** Various cults around Singapore could be seen in a theatre (7,7)
- 15** Direct ones acted and they’re related (9)
- 16** Romantic thought and inclination (8)
- 17** Filmed occasionally, photographed outside top Paris strip joint (8)
- 19** Standard to disqualify her, they say (6)
- 20** Soothe with an ointment — cover exposed neck (6)
- 22** State after a pile up (5)

SOLUTION NO. 60



Thomas Jacob
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The 1990 FIFA World Cup will always remain intertwined in my memory with the cold, rain-soaked nights of the southwest monsoon in Kerala. Even today, when the first rain of the season arrives in June, carrying the scent of wet earth and the sound of water dripping from coconut leaves, my mind travels back to Kannattumodi, a small village near Mavelikara, where, as a 24-year-old football fanatic, I lived through one of the most unforgettable months of my life.

Television was still a novelty in Kerala then. Though Doordarshan arrived in the State after the 1982 Asian Games, TV ownership remained limited. By 1990, however, television sets were slowly finding their way into homes, becoming windows to a larger world. Italia '90 was perhaps the first World Cup that many ordinary Malayalis could follow live from start to finish.

For a month, sleep became a luxury. Most matches were telecast late into the night. The monsoon outside made the experience even more magical. The rain would fall steadily on the tiled roofs. Frogs croaked from the paddy fields. Occasionally, a gust of wind would rattle the windows. Wrapped in a thin shawl against the chill, I would sit with eyes glued to the screen, my eyes fixed on distant stadiums in Italy.

The World Cup transformed those nights. Matches were played thousands of kilometres away in Italy, yet they seemed strangely close. Every night, after dinner, we the fans prepared ourselves for another vigil. The world outside disappeared into darkness and rain, while the television screen bathed the room in a soft glow.

The football fever was infectious. Every morning, conversations shifted from crop prices and local politics to goals, penalties, and refereeing decisions. Youngsters debated tactics. Elders who had never seen Italy on a map suddenly knew the names of Naples and Milan. The World Cup had arrived in rural Kerala.

My heart belonged to Brazil. Like countless football lovers in Kerala, I had grown up admiring the magic of Brazilian football. The yellow jersey symbolised joy, creativity, and artistry. Though the Brazil team of 1990 was more pragmatic than the dazzling sides of earlier decades, I believed they would go all the way. Then came the heartbreak.

Brazil dominated much of their Round of 16 match against Argentina. Time and again, they attacked, only to be denied by bad luck and stubborn defending. Then, in a cruel twist, Diego

Maradona produced a moment of brilliance, setting up Claudio Caniggia for the winning goal. I remember the silence that followed. The rain continued outside, but the excitement inside me vanished instantly. Brazil were out. For days, I carried that disappointment with me.

Yet the tournament marched on. Cameroon captured the world's imagination. West Germany

A heap of tales from the backyard

Vidya Vasudevan
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At a storytelling session, I could hear a voice telling eager listeners, “There could be tales hidden in every nook and corner, even in the most unlikely of places, if only you care to look for them.”

The ubiquitous compost pit in the farthest corner of my garden, nestled amid the coconut, drumstick, jackfruit, and gooseberry trees, is not eye-catching like the flowering plants occupying the rest of the garden space, but it keeps doing its work silently, coming up with new tales, now and then.

Fruit and vegetable waste in small buckets from the kitchen, and piles of dry leaves, flowers, and chopped grass are added to it together with some cow dung slurry. Months later, a day would arrive when the contents of the pit would be transformed into nutrient-rich, chemical-free compost, giving me a sense of satisfaction that the waste generated in the garden did not reach a landfill.

A visit to the backyard to pluck some drumsticks or its leaves or fallen gooseberries would mean there would inevitably be a “you know what happened” narrative such as a long piece of snake skin found lying on the heap causing a “jaw-dropping” moment or a sudden “thud” caused by a falling coconut, landing right in the centre of the heap, making it literally a “jump out of the skin” moment.

As I stepped over the heap to collect the coconut, I could feel the heap going down in the middle, telling me that the decaying process was ongoing. A huge jackfruit lying split wide open in the middle of the pit, with its insides ravaged, meant that the local troop of monkeys had made their daily visit.

Often birds such as coucals, bulbuls, woodpeckers, treepies, mynahs, crows, yellow-billed babblers, pigeons, drongos, koels or robins would land on the trees surrounding the heap, at various times of the day and regale us with their music but you had to practise tiptoeing to catch a glimpse of them.

Meanwhile, the wind is busy. It has blown a pile of leaves near the heap and along with it a plastic cover. I pick up the intruder. The whole process will start again.

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I have spent much of my life believing that affection must be earned. You work hard, help people, remember birthdays, support friends through crises, and show up when needed. If you are lucky, people appreciate you. If you are very lucky, they love you. Then along came Nico and completely transformed my understanding of human relationships. Nico is my dog. Or rather, he is the family dog who has somehow decided that I am the most important person in the household. This will be understandable if I was the one who fed him, walked him, groomed him or bathed him. I do none of these things. Yet Nico is devoted to me.

Every morning, when I wake up, he appears by my bedside. When I sit down with my tea and newspaper, he settles beside me. When I go to bed, he jumps onto the bed within minutes.



When a dog chooses its best friend

Along came the canine and transformed the understanding of human relationships

Before going for a walk, he comes to me as if seeking permission. On returning, he comes straight back to me as though reporting that all is well with the world. The truth is that my contribution to his life is embarrassingly modest. I pat him while reading the newspaper. When he wedges himself close to me on the sofa, I call him

my hand rest. Recently, I made the mistake of reading about dog behaviour. Experts explain that dogs form deep attachments. They choose favourite humans. The more I read, the more emotional I became. And then the guilt set in. Was I doing enough for him? The question troubled me because I belong to a

generation that is comfortable giving, striving and earning. Receiving something precious without having worked for it feels slightly uncomfortable.

A relationship in which one party contributes very little and receives such abundance of love and affection feels strangely undeserved. But perhaps I have been looking at the relationship the wrong way.

Nico does not seem particularly concerned about who fills his food bowl. What appears to matter to him is that I am there when he wakes up, there when he returns from his walk, and there when he settles down for the night. As I grow older, I am beginning to appreciate the wisdom in that.

We learn to equate love with effort, and worth with achievement. Then a dog comes along and quietly ignores all those rules. I still cannot explain why Nico is so attached to me. It makes very little sense. But I have stopped trying to deserve it.

The scents and scenes of ‘home’

The subtle sound of falling flowers and fragrance of a few blooms

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Ever since I moved from Kerala to Jamshedpur when it was part of Bihar, I have noticed my Keralite colleagues in the hospital getting excited on the approach of summer holidays. After booking tickets, they would beamingly tell me, “Natti povunnu.” In the late 1970s and for several years since then, a train journey of

nearly three days was the only travel option. Over the years, as air connectivity has improved, the three days spent in a train has been reduced to 12 hours from one home to another. From the airport, my brother or nephew drive us back home along the Shangumughom beach. On one such visit, my nephew told me that the sea had claimed part of the land. On a subsequent trip, he proclaimed proudly, “We reclaimed



our land from the sea!” We drove along the newly laid road, safely stone-walled; still, there was no beach to walk upon.

The city itself had undergone a steady transformation. Out of the three heritage houses in the heart of the city, two looked unoccupied and I wondered whether they would also get pulled down. The third, my ancestral house tucked away from the main road, will probably escape

getting annexed.

A day before my departure, I woke up at 5 a.m. to a faint tip-tip-tip sound outside the bedroom. I saw a gentle, slow and steady shower of small star-shaped light brown flowers from a Fishtail palm tree. In the stillness and quiet of pre-dawn, the sound of the flowers was surreal and soothing. With a sense of peace, I moved to the poo mugappu, the hexagonal front hall. A faint fragrance from the scanty flowers of a henna plant wafted through the bamboo curtains. The ephemeral subtle sound of falling flowers and the fragrance of a few blooms got added to my perception of what “home” means. Once again, homecoming was comforting.

ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR



Sleepless nights watching the beautiful game

Remembering Italia '90, the dream nights when the roar of the game mixed with the cadences of rain

displayed remarkable consistency. Argentina fought their way through adversity. Night after rainy night, I continued watching, despite my shattered hopes.

The final in Rome saw West Germany defeat Argentina 1-0 through Andreas Brehme's penalty. The Germans lifted the trophy. I watched the celebrations with admiration.

Thirty-six years have passed since those monsoon nights. Television has changed. Football has changed. Kerala has changed. But whenever the southwest monsoon arrives and the rain taps gently against the window, I can still see that flickering Doordarshan screen at Kannattumodi. I can still feel the chill of those sleepless nights, hear the distant thunder, and remember the dreams of a 24-year-old football lover who fell even deeper in love with the beautiful game.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

The Granta episode shows publishing has no real safeguards against AI-generated work slipping through. ('Children of the prompt'; June 14) Detection tools remain unreliable, as Mia Ballard's case proved. Publishers must build editorial transparency into contracts, requiring authors to declare AI involvement honestly.

A. Myilsami

With the advent of AI-assisted chat-boats, creative writing has been significantly impacted. As such, it will be a challenging endeavour for publishers to weed out plagiarised works.

G. Ramasubramanyam

Understanding intent

Marjane Satrapi's passing reminds us how powerful graphic storytelling can be in conveying lived experience. ('The complicated legacy of Marjane Satrapi'; June 17) Yet, the piece rightly notes how such work gets appropriated into agendas the author never intended. Readers must learn to separate an artist's original intent from its later political misuse, rather than judging the work itself by that misuse.

K. Sakunthala

Lifelong injury

Nadal's career is inspiring, but the docuseries also exposes how young athletes are pushed too early into gruelling training. ('Rafael Nadal: the anatomy of endurance'; June 14) The Mueller-Weiss syndrome, traced to childhood coaching, should worry parents and sports academies alike. Policymakers must set clear age-appropriate

training norms so future champions aren't built at the cost of lifelong injury.

Prajesh Paramasivan

The grace and swift movements of Rafael Nadal cannot be matched by any other player. His sangfroid while playing against giants such as Novak Djokovic and Roger Federer was always pleasing to watch.

K. Pradeep

Old gem

This article reminded me of the first black-and-white Indian film, *Raja Harishchandra*, directed by Dadasaheb Phalke in 1913. ('The B&W comeback'; June 14) Movies with strong messages and values, whether in color or black and white, continue to attract cinema lovers.

Sajna Hameed

Double standards

The piece on 'screeniority' captures a real generational double standard. ('Why didn't you let me read?'; June 14) Many elders who once discouraged children from reading now spend hours on phones at gatherings. Families should set simple shared rules, no devices during meals or social functions, applying equally to all ages.

Pon. Arun Kumar

Informative read

The revival of botanical illustrations in *Flora Indica* by Henry Noltie is a commendable effort towards restoring this declining art. ('These flowers have a backstory'; June 14) Plant species discovered centuries ago could yield valuable evidence of historical events and pave the way for the discovery of new species.

Monita Sutherson



MORE ON THE WEB
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When elections were a festival

In Bengal, flags and festoons and heated debates were part of polls

Buddhadev Nandi

Troubles of teachers

What if a 'student' tries to bribe one

K.S.S. Pillai

Web series over movies

Many advantages in making the choice, including watching from the comfort of home

Irfan Syed

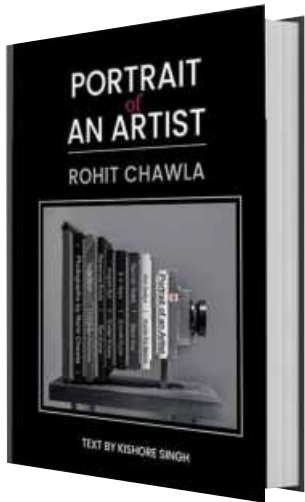
In search of the perfect cashback

The neighbourhood shop buying old newspapers runs the finest reward systems ever designed

Abhinav Banka

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(Clockwise from right) Studios of Anjolie Ela Menon; Atul Dodiya; Akbar Padamsee; T. Venkanna; and Mithu Sen; and (bottom right) photographer Rohit Chawla. (COURTESY ROHIT CHAWLA)



Nidhi Gupta

There is a word photographer Rohit Chawla returns to again and again when describing his life's work: trespassing. For the first four decades of his career – shooting prime ministers and film stars, artists and authors, for the covers and inside the pages of the country's most prestigious magazines – he used to feel “lucky to be able to meet a particular actor or writer”. He was the interloper with the camera, grateful for whatever the subject chose to reveal. But something has shifted. “Now, at this stage of my life,” he says, “I look back and feel that I belong in this whole thing. Now, I can chronicle my own life rather than trespass.”

This almost melancholic observation informs his latest book in subtle ways. *Portrait of an Artist*, published by the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art in New Delhi and co-published by Mapin Publishing (₹2,500), brings together 67 portraits of Indian artists spanning generations and mediums – from S.H. Raza and Akbar Padamsee to Bharti Kher and Shilpa Gupta, from the late masters Tyeb Mehta and Bhupen Khakhar to younger painters such as Kulpreet Singh. The text, crystalline and unencumbered, is by the art critic Kishore Singh. The photographs are



INSIDE THE ARTIST'S STUDIO

Chawla's, except in the case of those he could not meet. And the method, as ever, is spare: no assistants, no artificial lights, no rearranging of spaces. “Most of the images [in the book] were just me and the artist one-on-one,” he says. That solitude, he believes, is what makes honesty possible, and increasingly rare.

In an era of relentless image management, when every magazine cover passes through a retoucher's hands and every artist has learnt to perform for the lens, Chawla's instinct is to strip the encounter down to something closer to a conversation. He is, he acknowledges, something of a psychoanalyst with a camera. “Having spent almost four decades behind it, it gives you a peculiar kind of tunnel vision,” he says. “The camera holds this power – whoever is opposite, a prime minister, Robert De Niro, Vikram Seth, they all become human.”

Looking for calm
The book's architecture reflects the ambition of the project, one that began almost accidentally when Chawla shot Anjolie Ela Menon as Frida Kahlo in 2010. It is divided into two halves, the portrait and



the studio. Together they form an argument: that the working space of an artist is not a backdrop but a text, as legible as the work itself. As Kiran Nadar writes in her foreword, “The studio is never merely a room. It is simultaneously sanctuary and battleground, meditation space and laboratory, refuge and prison.” Chawla's photographs make this visible.

Some, like Amit Ambalal, Akbar Padamsee and G.R. Iranna's studios, are replete with the sort of magnificent chaos you'd expect of an artist's private creative space – full of paints, brushes, canvases and easels. But they

always signify something about the artist's process or worldview. The silence that Surendran Nair thinks art demands is reflected in the clean geometry of his studio. Nilima Sheikh's “beautiful, clean” studio underlines her quest for “*sukoon* [calm]”, in mild contrast to her partner Gulammohammad Sheikh's space, where he finds home, surrounded by his books, brushes and paints and a film projector. Arpita Singh works in a cordoned off area in her living room; Jyoti Bhatt

paints from his dining table. The range is the point. No two studios, like no two practices, are alike. Mithu Sen, painter, provocateur, self-described possible witch, lives and works in a studio in Surajkund in Haryana that seems to embody her contradictions. Open rooms lined with what Singh



calls her “Museum of Unbelongings”: shelves packed with dolls, busts, a dildo, a mermaid skeleton, breasts in various sizes, dried leaves. Sen herself holds it all loosely. “If someone says, leave this studio, I can – without looking back,” she says. For Chawla, this is exactly the kind of portrait that resists the curated self, the performed identity. Then there is T. Venkanna, the Hyderabad-based painter whose canvases of corporeal bodies and lurking violence place him in a lineage with K. Laxma Goud and Ravinder Reddy. When Venkanna returned from Vadodara to Hyderabad in 2023, he built his home inside his studio, folding kitchen and bedroom into the workspace. “My mind as well as my soul reside in my studio,” says the artist. “I think twice before leaving it to go out on work.” Some of the book's most indelible images belong to artists who are not among us, including Ram Kumar, Manjit Bawa and Tyeb Mehta. Their inclusion, rather than diluting the project, deepens it. As Singh writes: with their studios now silent, these

portraits function not just as documentation but as memorial – the preservation of something essential about how they worked and thought.

Shooting 300 authors
Chawla, who now lives and works out of a “sparse” studio in Assagao, Goa, is completing a book of portraits of 300 authors for the Jaipur Literature Festival, to mark 20 years of JLF, to be published in 2027. He came to authors, he says, out of intimidation: he used to feel daunted by them, and the portraits were his way of learning to see them clearly. In a moment when artificial intelligence can generate a plausible image of anything, the argument for the photograph as a document of human interaction, of human life, becomes both more urgent, and more difficult, to make. Chawla makes it anyway. “A photograph only has value if it is real,” he says. “If something actually happened.”

The Mumbai-based independent journalist writes on culture, lifestyle and technology.



Satyajit Ray on the set of *Ghare Baire*; and (right) the director. (COURTESY DAG)

Sanjukta Sharma

The photography of Nemai Ghosh, best known for his photo-biography of auteur Satyajit Ray, captured over 23 years, has busy, layered frames. Yet, as in the best of still photography, the focus is always on eloquent moments.

Take the images from *Faces and Facets: Satyajit Ray in Colour*, an ongoing exhibition at DAG, of 126 colour photos taken by him of Ray at work between 1970 and 1991. In one photo clicked on the set of *Ghare Baire* (1984), Ray is directing lead actress Swatilekha Sengupta in front of a mirror. Sengupta seems to be taking in instructions as the director himself, looking down, fingers placed against the mirror, is focused intensely on a detail that he wants in the frame. Ghosh's lens is as focused on Ray's face and hands as Ray's is on how to perfect that scene or frame.

Ghosh was Ray's friend-cum-biographer, destined to a life in photography after a friend gave him a Canonet QL17 fixed-lens camera found left behind in a taxi. He started using it to chronicle Calcutta, among other things. A few

years later, in 1968, Ray's art director Bansi Chandragupta asked him to join the production unit as a still photographer.

The exhibition celebrates the photographer's legacy – and, of course, his subject, the most well-known Indian filmmaker around the world both critically and historically. But, more importantly for the Artificial Intelligence (AI) age, the show offers the meditative and nuanced experience of looking at analogue photography.

From a pre-influencer era
Ray doesn't go out of fashion. Recently, an archival clip of Ray defending his anti-religious dogma stance in his 1960 film *Devi* became viral. In the interview, in his cut-glass English, he says: Indian audiences are “fairly backward” and “unsophisticated”. That quickly turned into a polarising debate about what is good cinema. Bollywood and populism supremacists even used director Aditya Dhar's words to argue that Ray, who would have been 105 this year, was elitist and disconnected from mass audiences. Defending his superhit *Dhuranidhar* (2025) against those who found it propagandist,



Nemai Ghosh's photographs, on show at DAG, preserve the auteur's creative life as a slow act of observation – a timely lesson in the age of AI

Dhar had said, “The Indian audience is actually very very smart.”

But what's striking about this show is the work behind the fixed-lens camera of Ghosh. Beyond Ray's historical and influential value – and his view of the world and audiences – Ghosh recorded moments that make us see the slow burn process of the director's craft,

and what went into the dilated architecture of a Ray film.

One image has Ray in the middle of editing with the Moviola machine (the first editing machine to be invented), with a tea cup in one hand, curiosity, a sense of urgency and fastidiousness informing his facial expressions. In a few of the images, spread over DAG's sprawling space, we see Ray in moments of



I have seen my father with a camera since the age of 10; I accompanied him to shoots of several Ray films. Just like *Manik-da* [Ray] was obsessed with perfecting his frames, my father was devoted to portraying *Manik-da* in all his moods. He didn't care so much about what happens after a shot is taken. I would do most of his post-shoot processing and printing work at our home

SATYAKI GHOSH
Nemai Ghosh's son and, as he calls himself, a “commercial photographer”

deep reflection in a book-crammed den at his Bishop Lefroy Road home in Kolkata.

Process is at the soul of this body of Ghosh's works. He was present on every set of Ray's films beginning with *Goopy Gyne Bagha Byne* (1969) – unobtrusive but intentional. Ashish Anand, CEO and managing director, DAG, explains, “What distinguishes Ghosh's work is that it is rooted in sustained observation. He did not photograph Satyajit Ray as a celebrity or public figure alone; he photographed a life, a creative temperament over more than two decades. There is patience, trust and an extraordinary depth of looking in these images.”

Archiving cultural memory
Much of the rich documentation of Ray's legacy points to the fact that his world was built on process. Whether designing a poster, composing a score or directing a film, he approached every task with the same seriousness of purpose. What distinguishes this repository of

photographs is also its historical and representative significance. It preserves a visual record of a particular kind of Indian cinema beyond the scope of mass media and formulaic adaptation.

DAG acquired the rights for Ghosh's photographs of Ray, his actors and film sets, and around 120,000 negatives, from the photographer himself in 2006. Ghosh passed away in 2020 at the age of 85. By then, his work had already received considerable national and international recognition through exhibitions and screenings associated with platforms such as the Cannes Film Festival and Festival d'Automne à Paris.

Says Anand, “Through photography, we gain access to artistic processes, social histories and lived experiences that might otherwise be lost. For younger audiences, archives such as Ghosh's help develop visual literacy – the ability to read images critically and understand how they shape our understanding of history.”

Ray is the filmmaker he is because he is rooted in the local sinews of Bengal, in the best of 19th and early 20th century Bengali literature, in order to achieve the density he talks about. Ghosh's fixed-lens camera captures this quality in him. The same density came to be found in Ghosh's work, too – not deliberately framed, but as real moments leading up to crafting cinema that the world doesn't forget.

Faces and Facets: Satyajit Ray in Colour, at DAG, Delhi, till July 4.

The writer is a Mumbai-based journalist and health advocate, and behind the preventive health and longevity media IP @the_slow_fix.